neighbours can see. Especially in India, there's a prestige thing about buying a car.'

Wagh also admits that a car lies in the 'aspirational space'; it is an acquisition to exhibit to society that a 'family has arrived'. Therefore, presenting the Nano as a cheap buy was antithetical to the social symbolism a car purchase would otherwise have accorded. Tata Motors 'could not break the paradigm' of the Nano being seen as a cheap car, he adds. Kant voices almost the same opinion. Nobody saw the Nano as 'an innovation marvel', he laments.

Noel Tata says that as soon as the average citizen starts earning more, they prefer a bigger car. 'The second-hand market had started growing by leaps and bounds so if you put two and two together, I think customers preferred to buy a bigger second-hand car than to be seen in the cheapest car in the world,' he says.

In an interview in 2013, Ratan admitted that it was a mistake to market the Nano on the price: 'It became termed as [the] cheapest car by the public and, I am sorry to say, by ourselves, not by me, but the company when it was marketing it. I think that is unfortunate.'

Ironically, though the Nano immediately brings to mind a figure of Rs 1 lakh, it was not, in reality, a 1-lakh car. The launch price of Nano variants ranged between Rs 1.12-1.85 lakh. Rising input costs also put pressure on margins. This increase of around 15 per cent took the cost beyond what many first-time buyers could afford. Those who could afford a better model went for the 'more sophisticated vehicles' like those produced by Maruti.

Patrick Whitney, recognized as a 'design visionary', remarked that the 'Tatas may have lost an opportunity in [the] Nano by not positioning it as a product of choice for the middle and upper-middle-class consumers in [the] developed world and then sold it in India [sic]. Instead by marketing directly to the middle class and lower middle class in India, the product ignored the aspirational ambitions of the class of people it is currently targeting'.

Repackaging the Nano

The first upgrade of the Nano was undertaken a year after its commercial launch, in 2010, and one of the last was in 2019. Over the years, the gap between other cheap cars on the road and the Nano narrowed. The lowest